

Active and Passive Voice

Voice refers to the form of a verb that indicates when a grammatical *subject* **performs** the action or is the *receiver* of the action.

Most English verbs have two voice.

- The active voice
 - The passive voice
- ✓ When the verb is in **active voice**, the subject of the sentence is the that **perform** the action.(the subject does the action).
- ✓ When the verb is in **passive voice**, the subject of the sentence is the **reciver** of the action (the subject recives the action).

Rules of changing active sentence to passive sentence

1. The sentence must have objects (contain transitive verb).

A verb can be either transitive or intransitive.

Transitive verbs: are verbs that require an object in a sentence in order to give complete meaning. It needs an object (in sentence) to give complete meaning. A sentence can be changed into passive voice if it has subject and object. Therefore, we form passive sentence with transitive verbs, which take objects.

Intransitive verbs: are verbs that do not require object in the sentence and can give complete meaning with out an object in the sentence. So, Intransitive verb cannot be changed into passive voice. The sentences having intransitive verbs (belonging to any tense) cannot be changed into passive voice. The reason is that there is not any object in such sentences and without object of sentence passive voice is not possible. Some common transitive verbs are:appear, arrive, come, become, go, happen, occur, rain stay, walk, run, resemble, etc...

Eg. **The baby is crying. The guests are arrived. The kids were smiling. He laughed. They're coming over. An accident has happened.** (cry, arrive smile laugh, come, happen = intransitive verbs. There are no objects; therefore there is no possibility of making these sentences into the passive voice)

2. *We change the object of active sentence into the subject of passive sentence.*

The places of subject and object are interchanged i.e. the object shifts to the place of subject and subject shifts to the place of object in passive voice.

3. *The "Be" form must be used according to the tense of the verb.*

i.e (be, am, is, are, was, were, being, been) followed by the past participle form of the main verb. Note that the form of the verb "to be" is singular or plural depending on the new subject of the sentence:

- Teachers **are using** the new book in their classrooms.

(teachers = plural, so we use "are")

- The new book **is being used** in classrooms.

(the new book = singular, so we use "is")

4. *Past participle (V3) form of the main verb must be used in sentences of passive voice for all tenses.*

5. *Preposition "by" can be added when the agent of the sentence is important.*

The word "by" is not always used before subject in passive voice. Sometimes words "with, to, etc" may also be used before subject in passive voice.

- **Active voice:** The water fills the tub.
- **Passive voice:** The tub is filled with water.
- **Active voice:** He knows me.
- **Passive voice:** I am known to him

We do not include "by..." when:

- The doer of the action is **unknown:**



e.g *The money was stolen.*

- The doer of the action is "**people in general**":

e.g *Black cats are believed to bring bad luck.*

- The doer of the action is **completely unimportant**:

e.g *This bridge was built in 1889. (probably by a construction company)*

- For the **simple present tense** use **am, is or are** with a past participle to form the passive voice. i.e

Active : S+V1	Passive: S+am/is/are + past participle
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Active voice

The caretaker **locks** the door.

Passive voice

The doors **are locked** by the caretaker.

- For the **present continuous tense** use **am, is or are with being** followed by a past participle to form the passive voice.

Active :S+am/is/are + -ing	Passive: S+am/is/are + being + v3
Active voice	Passive voice

The singer is singing a song beautifully. The song is being sung beautifully by the singer.

- For the **present perfect tense** use **have or has with been** followed by a past participle to form the passive voice.

Active : S+has/have + -v3	Passive: S+has/have + been + -v3
Active voice	Passive voice

Ali has scored two goals.

Two goals have been scored by Ali.

They have built a large house.

A large house has been built by them.

- For the **simple past tense** use **was or were** with a past participle to form the passive voice.

Active :S + -v2	Passive: S+was/were + -v3
Active voice	Passive voice

He took these photos

These photos were taken by him.

- For the **past continuous tense** use **was or were with being** followed by a past participle to form the passive voice.

Active : S+was/were + -ing	Passive: S+was/were + being + -v3
Active voice	Passive voice

She was reading a book.

The book was being read by her.

- For the **past perfect tense** use **had with been** followed by a past participle to form the passive voice.

Active : S+had + v3	Passive:S+ had + been + -V3
Active voice	Passive voice

Ruth had given a gift to Abiy.

A gift had been given to Abiy by Ruth.

- For the **simple future tense** use **shall or will + be with being** followed by a past participle to form the passive voice.

Active :S+ will + v1	Passive: S+will + be + -v3
Active voice	Passive voice

We will celebrate her birthday.

Her birthday will be celebrated by us.

- For the *future perfect* use **shall or will with been** followed by a past participle to form the passive

Active : will + have + v3	Passive: will + have + been + v3
Active voice	Passive voice

John will have repaired his bicycle. His bicycle will have been repaired by John.

- For **imperatives** use **let with be** followed by a part participle to form the passive voice. **Let + subject+ be +v3**

Active voice	Passive voice
Give up smoking.	Let smoking be given up.
Shut the door	Let the door be shut.
Never tell a lie	Let a lie be never told
Switch on the light.	Let the light be witched on
Respect elders	Let the elder be respected
Stand up.	You are ordered to stand up.

- For **infinitives** use **Subject + verb + Object + to be** followed by a part participle to form the passive voice.

Active voice	Passive voice
I wan to write the letter.	I want the letter to be written
I need to deliver the lesson.	I need the lesson to be delivered.
I want to invite her to the party.	I want her to be invited to the party.
I have to do this work.	This work has to be done.
I want to buy this book.	I want this book to be bought.

- To form the passive voice of **a present modal: modal+ be+ v3**

Active voice	Passive voice
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He could repair the car in two days.

The car could be repaired in two days.

Students should study the lessons.

The lessons should be studied by students.

Meron can buy a new computer.

A new computer can be bought by Meron

- To form the passives of **Perfect modal: modal+ have+been+v3**

Active voice

He could have repaired the car in two days.

He might have eaten the meal.

You should have studied the book.

You may have availed the opportunity.

Passive voice

The car could have been repaired in two days.

The meal might have been eaten by him.

The book should have been studied by you.

The opportunity may have been availed by you.

Note that: it is not common for us to change present perfect continuous, past perfect continuous, future continuous, and future perfect continuous in to passive voice. Structurally, we can change those tenses in to passiv but it is better to use their active voice instead of their passive form. When we change this tenses to passive the sentence become sound awkward.

Double object verbs

When we have two objects in a sentence, we can form our passive sentence by select one of the two objects that we want to emphasise. Some verbs that take two objects are: give tell, send, show, bring, write, pay, offer, etc....

- Active: Meron gave me this book.
- Passive1: The book was given to me by Meron.
- Passive 2: I was given this book by Mary.

When we use passive passive voice?

- When the agent is not known.

The door is broken. i.e we dont know who broke the door.

laptop **was stolen** from the classroom.

Three people **have been killed** in the park. Police are looking for clues to the identity of the murderer.

➤ When we don't want to mention the agent. i.e we know the subject who perform the action, but we are not voluntary to mention (keep in secret) the performer of the action.

➤ When we want to emphasize the object rather than the subject

The presidant was killed in 1998. Here the empasize is not on the performer of the action rather the reciver of the action.

➤ When we want to emphasize the agent

The new library will be opened by the Queen. Here the emphasize is not on the new library ; the focus is who will open it.

Interrogative Passive Rules

Active Voice

Passive Voice

1. Do/does + subject + verb + object ?	Am/is/are + subject + V3 + by + agent ?
2. Am/is/are + subject + verb + ing + object ?	Am/is/are + subject + being + V3 + by + agent ?
3. Did + subject + verb + object ?	Was/were + subject + V3 + by + agent ?
4. Was/were + subject + verb + ing + object ?	Was/were + subject + being + V3 + by + agent ?
5. Have/has/had + subject + V-3 + object ?	Have/has/had + subject + been + V3 + by + agent ?
6. Modal + subject + verb + object ?	Modal + subject + be + V3 + by + agent ?
7. 'Wh' word + auxiliary + subject + verb + object ?	Wh' word + auxiliary + subject + V3 + agent ?

How to change voice of interrogative sentences.

1. *Questions beginning with do/does*

Normal structure of interrogative sentence in active voice starting with do/does is

Do/does + subject + verb + object ? (Active Voice)

Ex: Does she cook the food? (Active Voice) (Here 'she' is subject, 'cook' is verb and 'the food' is object.)

While changing the sentence into passive, this structure becomes:

Am/is/are + subject + V3 + by + agent ? (Passive Voice)

Ex: Is the food cooked by her? (Passive Voice) (Here 'The food' becomes subject in passive voice, 'cooked' is V3 (past participle) of cook, and 'her' is agent (doer))

See some more examples to clarify this:

- *Does Selam write homework? (Active Voice)*
Is homework written by Selam? (Passive Voice)
- *Does Daniel read the books? (Active Voice)*
Are the books read by Daniel? (Passive Voice)
- *Do they decorate the room with flowers.?* (Active Voice)
Is the room decorated with flowers by them? (Passive Voice)

2. Questions beginning with am/is/are

Normal structure of interrogative sentence in active voice starting with am/is/are

is: Am/is/are + subject + verb + ing + object ? (Active Voice)

Ex: Is she cooking the food? (Active Voice) (Here 'she' is subject, 'cooking' is verb and 'the food' is object.)

While changing the sentence into passive, this structure becomes

Am/is/are + subject + being + V-3 + by + agent ? (Passive Voice)

Ex: Is the food being cooked by her? (Passive Voice) (Here 'The food' becomes subject in passive voice, 'cooked' is V3 (past participle) of cook, and 'her' is agent (doer))

Note: You might have noticed that whenever there is verb + ing in active voice, we are using being + V3 in passive voice.

See some more examples to clarify this

➤ *Is Selam writing homework? (Active Voice)*

Is homework being written by Selam? (Passive Voice)

➤ *Are Selam and Meron playing cricket? (Active Voice)*

Is cricket being played by selam and Meron? (Passive Voice)

3. Questions beginning with did

***Normal structure of interrogative sentence in active voice starting with did is
Did + subject + verb + object ? (Active Voice)***

Ex: Did she cook the food? (Active Voice) (Here 'she' is subject, 'cook' is verb and 'the food' is object.)

***While changing the sentence into passive, this structure becomes
Was/were + subject + V-3 + by + agent ? (Passive Voice)***

Ex: Was the food cooked by her? (Passive Voice) (Here 'The food' becomes subject in passive voice, 'cooked' is V-3 (past participle) of cook, and 'her' is agent (doer))

See some more examples to clarify this

✓ *Did John write homework? (Active Voice)*

Was homework written by John? (Passive Voice)

- ✓ *Did the students read books? (Active Voice)*
Were books read by the students ? (Passive Voice)

4. Questions beginning with was/were

Normal structure of interrogative sentence in active voice starting with was/were is: Was/were + subject + verb + ing + object ? (Active Voice)

Ex: Was she cooking the food? (Active Voice) (Here 'she' is subject, 'cooking' is verb and 'the food' is object.)

While changing the sentence into passive, this structure becomes:

Was/were + subject + being + V-3 + by + agent ? (Passive Voice)

Ex: Was the food being cooked by her? (Passive Voice) (Here 'The food' becomes subject in passive voice, 'cooked' is V-3 (past participle) of cook, and 'her' is agent (doer))

See some more examples to clarify this

- ✓ *Was John writing Letters? (Active Voice)*
Were letters being written by John? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Were they eating their lunch? (Active Voice)*
Was their lunch being eaten? (Passive Voice)

5. Questions beginning with have/has/had

Normal structure of interrogative sentence in active voice starting with have/has/had is: Have/has/had + subject + V-3 + object ? (Active Voice)

Ex: Has she cooked the food? (Active Voice) (Here 'she' is subject, 'cooked' is V-3 (past participle) of cook and 'the food' is object.)

While changing the sentence into passive, this structure becomes:

Have/has/had + subject + been + V-3 + by + agent ? (Passive Voice)

Ex: Has the food been cooked by her? (Passive Voice) (Here 'The food' becomes subject in passive voice, 'cooked' is V3 (past participle) of cook, and 'her' is agent (doer))

See some more examples to clarify this:

✓ *Have they changed the date of the meeting? (Active Voice)*

Has the date of the meeting been changed by them? (Passive Voice)

✓ *Have archaeologists discovered ancient temple? (Active Voice)*

✓ *Has an ancient temple been discovered by archeologists? (Passive voice)*

✓ *Had somebody cleaned my shoes? (Active Voice)*

Had my shoes been cleaned? (Passive Voice)

6. Questions beginning with modals

Normal structure of interrogative sentence in active voice starting with modals is:

Modal + subject + verb + object ? (Active Voice)

Ex: Can she cook the food? (Active Voice) (Here 'she' is subject, 'cook' is V-3 verb and 'the food' is object.)

While changing the sentence into passive, this structure becomes:

Modal + subject + be + V3 + by + agent ? (Passive Voice)

Ex: Can the food be cooked by her? (Passive Voice) (Here 'The food' becomes subject in passive voice, 'cooked' is V3 (past participle) of cook, and 'her' is agent (doer))

See some more examples to clarify this:

- ✓ *Should students study all lessons ? (Active Voice)*
Should all lessons be studied by students? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Can he write a poem? (Active Voice)*
Can the letter be written by him? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *May I buy the computer? (Active Voice)*
May the computer be bought by me? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Could he repair the car? (Active voice)*
Could the car be repaired by him? (passive voice)

7. 'Wh' questions

Questions starting with what, why, where, when, who, whom etc are known as 'wh' questions

Normal structure of 'wh' questions in active voice is:

'Wh' word + auxiliary + subject + verb + object ? (Active Voice)

Ex: *Why did she punish you? (Active Voice) (Here 'she' is subject, 'punish' is verb and 'you' is object.)*

While changing the sentence into passive, this structure becomes:

'Wh' word + auxiliary + subject + V-3 + agent ? (Passive Voice)

Ex: *Why were you punished by her? (Passive Voice) (Here 'you' becomes subject in passive voice, 'punished' is V-3 (past participle) of punish, and 'her' is agent*

(doer))

See some more examples to clarify this:

- ✓ *Where do you read books? (Active Voice)*
Where are the books read by you? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Where had he taken Priya? (Active Voice)*
Where Priya had been taken by him? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *What motivates you? (Active Voice)*
By what you are motivated? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *What did you eat? (Active Voice)*
What was eaten by You? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *When are you giving her the key? (Active Voice)*
When the key is being given to her by you? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Which book did you purchase? (Active Voice)*
Which book was purchased by you? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Why do you read books?(Active Voice)*
Why are books read by you? (Passive Voice)

Questions beginning with ‘who’

In such kind of sentences who acts as subject.

See some examples to clear this:

- ✓ *Who wrote this letter? (Active Voice)*
By whom this letter was written? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Who will call him? (Active Voice)*
By whom he will be called? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Who painted this beautiful painting? (Active Voice)*
By whom was this beautiful painting painted? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Who invited you? (Active Voice)*
By whom were you invited? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Who lent you this book? (Active Voice)*
By whom were you lent this book? (Passive Voice)

Questions beginning with ‘whom’

- ✓ *Whom is John inviting? (Active Voice)*
Who is being invited by John? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Whom you invited in the party? (Active Voice)*
Who was invited by you in the party ? (Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Whom do you like? (Active Voice)*
Who is liked by you?(Passive Voice)
- ✓ *Whom has the principal honoured? (Active Voice)*

- Who has been honoured by the principal? (Passive Voice)*
- ✓ *Whom has the police arrested? (Active Voice)*
Who has been arrested by police? (Passive Voice)
 - ✓ *Whom have the people elected? (Active Voice)*
Who has been elected by the people? (Passive Voice)
 - ✓ *Whom have the selectors selected? (Active Voice)*
Who has been selected by the selectors? (Passive Voice)
 - ✓ *Whom has she called? (Active Voice)*
Who has been called by her? (Passive Voice)

Read the following magazine article. Pay special attention to verbs in the passive voice.

The Academy awards **are given** out every year to recognize outstanding work of movie actors, directors, and others who are part of the movie-making industry. These awards, called Oscars. Oscars **are presented** in a formal ceremony in Hollywood. Several people **are nominated** in specific categories, such as Best Movie, Best Actor, Best Music and Best Costumes. One nominee **is chosen** to receive an award in each category.

When the awards ceremony started in 1929, 15 awards **were presented** and the ceremony **was attended** by only 250 people. Tickets cost \$10 and any one who could afford a ticket could attend. Today about two dozen Oscars **are presented**. Tickets **are** no longer **sold** to the general public; invitations **are sent** only to people involved in making the movies and to their guests. Today the awards **are presented** in the 3400 seat Kodak Theatre in Hollywood.

Until 1941, the winners' names **were** already **known** before the ceremony and **published** in newspapers the night before the ceremony. Now the winners' names **are placed** in sealed envelopes and the envelopes **are not opened** until the night of the ceremony.

Since 1953, Oscar night has been televised and broadcast all over the world. This show is seen by hundreds of millions of people. Viewers watch as their favorite movie stars arrive looking beautiful and hopeful.

NB: both active and passive voice can be used with different tenses and with modals. The tense of the passive voice is shown in the verb 'to be'. Because in Passive voice, we use the past participle form of a base verb for every tense.

For Practice at Sentence Level

Direction: The following sentences are in the active voice. Change them into the passive voice.

1. The terrorist group killed the innocent people.
2. Voters often reject tax proposals.
3. Danawit is giving oral warning for Sam.
4. The actors had performed the play by Shakespeare.
5. Did you send a letter?
6. The painter created a beautiful painting.
7. The judge settles all disputes.
8. The students have written a test.
9. They cancelled all the flights because of fog.
10. Was she beating the child?
11. I must finish this assignment.
12. They are building a new ring-road round the city.
13. My mother will punish me.
14. They have changed the date of the meeting.

15. I have seen that movie.

16. Eyerus couldn't see the man.

17. John gave Elizabeth that beautiful ring.

18. I need to deliver the lesson

For Practice at paragraph Level

Choose the correct form of the verbs in brackets.

FIAT

Fiat was started (started/was started) by a group of Italian businessmen in 1899. In 1903, Fiat, 1 _____ (produced/was produced) 132 cars. Some of these cars 2 _____ (exported/were exported) by the company to the United States and Britain. In 1920, Fiat 3 _____ (started/was started) making cars at a new factory at Lingotto, near Turin. There was a track on the roof where the cars 4 _____ (tested/were tested) by technicians. In 1936, Fiat launched the Fiat 500. This car 5 _____ (called/was called) the Topolino – the Italian name for Mickey Mouse. The company grew, and in 1963 Fiat 6 _____ (exported/was exported) more than 300,000 vehicles. Today, Fiat is based in Turin, and its cars 7 _____ (sold/are sold) all over the world.